whereby Peshawar could remain under Ranjit Singh's nominal control until his death, when it would revert to the Afghans.[42]

Certainly it was with the confident hope that his mission could bring about some sort of compromise between the Sikhs and the Afghans that Burnes headed up the Khyber Pass on 30 August, passing through the no man's land separating the two warring parties. 'We took our departure from Peshawar,' he wrote later,

> and were driven by M Avitabile in his carriage to Jamrud, scene of the late battle between the Sikhs and the Afghans . . . We found the situation by no means agreeable. The deputation sent to escort us through the Khyber Pass had not yet arrived; and although some months had now elapsed since the battle, the effluvia from the dead bodies, both of men and horses was quite revolting. Some camel-keepers who had left the place the day of our arrival, escorted by a few soldiers, were attacked by the Afridi mountaineers, who came down upon them, drove off the camels, and beheaded two of the people, whose mangled trunks were brought into camp . . . [Halfway up the Khyber] by the road they showed us many small mounds, built to mark the spots where they had planted the heads of the Sikhs whom they had decapitated after the late victory: on some of these mounds locks of hair were yet to be seen.

As they passed from the territory of one tribe to another, 'stopped at every by-road and defile as we came among the different subdivisions of the tribe', the Embassy crossed slowly into Dost Mohammad's area of control. A few days later, after passing the chinars and cypresses of Shah Jahan's great Mughal garden at Nimla, site of Shah Shuja's first defeat by Dost Mohammad in 1809, Burnes was met by two men who would both play important roles in his life.

The first to ride into his camp was the British deserter turned spy and archaeologist Charles Masson. Burnes recorded in his account his pleasure at meeting Masson, who had now earned some celebrity in India thanks to his pioneering work digging the Bactrian Greek and Kushan Buddhist sites around Kabul and Jalalabad; Burnes described Masson in his diary as 'the well-known illustrator of Bactrian reliques', and praised him for his 'high literary attainments, long residence in this country, and accurate knowledge of people and events'.[43] But Masson, who had for many years known Afghanistan intimately and who was a confidant of Dost Mohammad, was much less enamoured by his ambitious and self-promoting celebrity visitor. Like many others, he strongly resented Burnes's fame as a traveller on the basis of his single journey to Bukhara, and was extremely dubious about both Burnes's geographical knowledge and his diplomatic skills. 'I must